THE DEAD DON'T FORGET

FREE SAMPLE

Episode 1 — The Man at the Gate

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THE DEAD DON'T FORGET — Episode 1: "The Man at the Gate"

Full script (Maya's original — use word for word)

The first thing Daniel Vale noticed was that the man outside the gate wasn't trying to get in.

That was wrong.

Everybody tried to get in.

That was the rule now.

Hungry people tried to get in.

Armed people tried to get in.

Sick people tried to get in.

People pretending not to be sick tried to get in.

Children tried to get in.

Thieves tried to get in.

Mothers carrying children tried to get in.

Men carrying guns tried to get in.

People who had spent three weeks alone in houses with no electricity and no food tried to get in.

Sometimes they begged.

Sometimes they lied.

Sometimes they threatened.

Once, three men had stood outside the western gate for almost six hours claiming they were federal contractors.

Daniel had asked what agency.

They couldn't agree.

One said FEMA.

One said Homeland Security.

The third said they were from the Department of Transportation.

Daniel had laughed.

Then he'd ordered the guards to fire warning shots.

They left.

That was how the world worked now.

The desperate came to the gate.

They wanted something.

Food.

Water.

Medicine.

Safety.

The dead wanted something too.

But Daniel didn't know that yet.

He stood in the warehouse office with a paper cup of coffee in one hand and a pistol in the other.

The coffee was cold.

He drank it anyway.

On the wall beside him hung a whiteboard.

Names covered it.

One hundred forty-three survivors.

Every person inside the warehouse had been assigned a number.

Not because Daniel didn't know their names.

Because numbers were easier.

Numbers didn't argue.

Numbers didn't get offended.

Numbers didn't ask why their neighbor received antibiotics while their own child didn't.

Numbers could be moved.

Transferred.

Crossed out.

Daniel stared at the board.

Someone had added another name.

He hadn't authorized it.

MELISSA HARPER — 144

Daniel turned.

The door opened.

Mara stood there.

She had blood on her scrubs.

Daniel's eyes went immediately to it.

"Yours?"

"No."

"Whose?"

"A boy."

"How bad?"

"He'll live."

Daniel nodded.

That was supposed to be good news.

Mara didn't smile.

"There's someone at the gate."

"I know."

"You've been watching?"

"Three minutes."

"How long has he been there?"

"Nine."

Mara looked through the dirty office window.

The warehouse lights flickered.

The backup generator coughed somewhere below them.

Outside, beyond the welded steel barricade and the stacked shipping containers, a figure stood in the road.

A man.

Or what used to be one.

He wore a gray maintenance uniform.

One sleeve was torn.

His head leaned slightly to the right.

His face was pale enough to look almost blue beneath the moonlight.

He wasn't moving.

Mara whispered, "Is he infected?"

Daniel didn't answer.

She looked at him.

"That's not what I asked."

"I know."

"Then answer."

Daniel put down his coffee.

"He's dead."

The radio on the desk crackled.

A guard spoke.

"Mr. Vale?"

Daniel picked it up.

"Go."

"He's still standing there."

"I can see him."

"Should we shoot?"

Daniel watched the figure.

"Wait."

A pause.

"Sir?"

"I said wait."

Mara stared at him.

"You don't know what it is."

"I know exactly what it is."

"No. You don't."

Daniel looked at her.

She wasn't frightened.

That was what worried him.

Fear made people predictable.

Mara was angry.

Angry people did stupid things.

"Get back inside," he said.

"No."

"Mara."

"You've been telling everyone else to stay inside for weeks."

"Because they're not doctors."

"I'm not talking about the gate."

Daniel looked at her.

She took a step toward him.

"You're getting worse."

"I'm tired."

"You haven't slept."

"I'm running a settlement."

"You're drinking more."

"There's no law against it."

"There doesn't have to be."

He looked away.

Mara's voice softened.

"How long since you spoke to Mom?"

Daniel didn't answer.

"Exactly."

"Mara."

"She thinks you're dead."

"That's convenient."

"She thinks you chose not to call."

Daniel's jaw tightened.

"I tried."

"Once."

"Three times."

"Three times?"

"Three times."

"And?"

"No answer."

Mara looked toward the gate.

Then back at him.

"You know what I think?"

"I rarely enjoy that sentence."

"I think you're relieved she didn't answer."

Daniel's face changed.

Only slightly.

But Mara noticed.

She always noticed.

Before the world ended, she'd spent years reading sick people.

She'd learned that the body confessed before the mouth did.

Daniel was confessing now.

Outside, something struck the gate.

Everyone froze.

Once.

A dull metallic boom.

Then silence.

Another.

Boom.

Boom.

The radio erupted.

"He's walking toward it."

Daniel picked it up.

"Nobody opens the gate."

"We weren't—"

"Nobody opens it."

The guard's voice trembled.

"Sir, he's looking at us."

Daniel walked toward the window.

The figure had moved.

Slowly.

Barely.

But it had moved.

Twenty feet closer.

Its face was visible now.

Daniel stared.

The room seemed to shrink around him.

Mara noticed.

"What?"

He didn't answer.

"Daniel."

The dead man lifted his head.

Moonlight caught his eyes.

Daniel's hand tightened around the pistol.

Mara stepped beside him.

"Do you know him?"

"No."

The dead man smiled.

It was a terrible thing.

Not because it was monstrous.

Because it was familiar.

Daniel had seen that smile before.

In photographs.

At dinner tables.

Across conference rooms.

On courthouse steps.

He had seen it in people who had just lost something and were trying not to let anyone see how badly it hurt.

The dead man lifted one hand.

His index finger pointed through the gate.

Directly at Daniel.

Mara whispered:

"Who is he?"

Daniel didn't breathe.

The man opened his mouth.

His voice was ruined.

Dry.

Almost too quiet to hear.

But the speakers around the gate carried it.

Everyone inside the warehouse heard the words.

"You remember me."

Daniel stepped backward.

Mara looked at him.

The dead man continued.

"You told me nobody would care."

Daniel's pistol lowered.

"No."

Mara's face changed.

"Daniel?"

The dead man's smile disappeared.

"You said I had no one."

Daniel whispered:

"Elias."

The warehouse went silent.

The name meant nothing to most of them.

But it meant everything to Daniel.

Elias Mercer.

Apartment 3B.

Cincinnati.

Maintenance supervisor.

Wife named Ruth.

Son named Caleb.

One unpaid mortgage.

Three months behind.

A bad back.

A disciplinary warning.

A building scheduled for demolition.

Daniel remembered the file.

He remembered the meeting.

He remembered Elias sitting across from him.

He remembered the man's hands.

That was the strange thing.

Daniel remembered his hands.

Not his face.

Not his voice.

His hands.

Large.

Calloused.

Resting on the table.

Elias had asked him one question.

"Is there anything I can do?"

Daniel had said no.

That wasn't true.

There had been something he could do.

Daniel could have stopped the eviction.

Could have found another building.

Could have refused the contract.

Could have walked away.

Instead, he'd signed another document.

And three months later Elias was dead.

Daniel had never attended the funeral.

Now Elias stood outside his gate.

Dead.

Waiting.

Mara stared at her father.

"You knew him."

Daniel didn't answer.

"You knew him."

"Yes."

"What did you do?"

Daniel looked through the window.

Elias hadn't moved.

Then Daniel noticed something.

There were others behind him.

At first he thought they were shadows.

Then one moved.

Another appeared.

Then another.

Mara whispered:

"Oh God."

Daniel counted.

Seven.

No.

Eleven.

No.

More.

Figures emerged from the darkness along the road.

All walking in the same direction.

Toward the warehouse.

Toward him.

The radio screamed.

"Mr. Vale!"

Daniel grabbed it.

"How many?"

"We can't count them."

"Open the south cameras."

"They're already on."

"Switch to infrared."

"We did."

"And?"

The guard's voice cracked.

"Sir..."

"What?"

"They're all looking at the warehouse."

Daniel closed his eyes.

The dead outside didn't rush.

They didn't pound against the fence.

They didn't scream.

They simply stood there.

Waiting.

Mara turned toward him.

"What did you do?"

Daniel didn't answer.

She grabbed his arm.

"What did you do?"

He pulled away.

"Get the medical team ready."

"Daniel—"

"Get everyone into the interior rooms."

"Why?"

"Because we're going to have a breach."

The words had barely left his mouth when the warehouse lights went out.

Darkness swallowed everything.

Somewhere below them, people screamed.

Daniel drew his pistol.

The emergency lights flickered red.

Mara whispered his name.

Daniel listened.

From outside came the sound of dozens of feet moving across concrete.

Slow.

Patient.

Unhurried.

Then the radio came alive.

A guard was screaming.

"They're at the eastern gate!"

Daniel ran.

Mara followed.

They reached the catwalk overlooking the main warehouse floor.

People were flooding toward the interior barricades.

Children crying.

Adults shouting.

Guards trying to organize them.

Daniel raised his voice.

"EVERYONE TO THE INNER WALL!"

The crowd began moving.

Then a gunshot cracked.

Someone fell.

Panic exploded.

Daniel pushed through the crowd.

"WHO FIRED?"

Nobody answered.

Another shot.

Daniel turned.

One of the guards stood near the eastern loading entrance.

His rifle was raised.

His face was white.

"Open the gate," someone shouted.

Daniel stared at him.

"Don't."

"They're coming through!"

"Hold it."

"We can't!"

"Hold it!"

The guard looked at him.

Then at the crowd.

Then back at the gate.

Something slammed against the other side.

The entire metal door shook.

The crowd screamed.

Daniel saw Mara.

She was helping a little girl behind the barricade.

He saw the child's mother.

Then he saw something else.

A face through the narrow reinforced window.

Elias.

Daniel stared at him.

Elias stared back.

And behind him stood dozens of dead people.

But Elias wasn't looking at the guards.

He wasn't looking at the door.

He was looking only at Daniel.

Then he lifted his hand.

And pointed toward the whiteboard.

Daniel's stomach dropped.

The office was fifty feet away.

The whiteboard was visible through the glass.

Names.

Numbers.

Lives.

Daniel suddenly understood.

The dead weren't attacking the warehouse.

They were following a list.

His list.

He turned toward the board.

Melissa Harper.

Number 144.

Daniel stared.

He had added her name himself.

That morning.

A woman whose husband had died three days earlier.

A woman whose ration card Daniel had almost revoked because she'd accused him of stealing antibiotics.

A woman who had told him that everyone inside the warehouse was becoming afraid of him.

Daniel had thought nothing of it.

Now her name sat beneath the others.

And beneath it, someone had written another name.

In handwriting Daniel didn't recognize.

DANIEL VALE — 000

Mara saw it too.

"What does that mean?"

Daniel couldn't speak.

The eastern gate began to bend inward.

Once.

Twice.

Then the metal screamed.

The guards raised their weapons.

Daniel looked at the dead outside.

For the first time since the collapse began, he felt something stronger than fear.

Recognition.

Not of Elias.

Not of the others.

Of himself.

He understood what was happening.

And he understood why they had come.

The dead had not forgotten.

They had simply been waiting.

The gate buckled.

Mara grabbed his arm.

"Dad."

Daniel looked at her.

"What?"

She pointed toward the road.

More figures were emerging from the darkness.

Dozens.

Then hundreds.

And among them, Daniel recognized another face.

A woman.

Old.

Gray-haired.

Wearing a blue city sanitation uniform.

Daniel knew her.

He had destroyed her pension.

Another figure walked beside her.

A teenage boy.

Daniel didn't recognize him.

Yet.

The boy stopped.

Turned his head.

And looked directly at Daniel.

Mara whispered:

"Who are they?"

Daniel couldn't answer.

Because he had finally realized the worst part.

The dead weren't coming for the warehouse.

They weren't coming for food.

They weren't coming for blood.

They were coming for him.

And there were enough of them to fill the entire road.

The eastern gate finally gave way.

Daniel raised his pistol.

Outside, Elias Mercer took one slow step forward.

And smiled.